Start Here: How to Use This Binder

Print it, fill it in (on screen or by hand), keep it where a backup person can find it.

This binder is for (parent's name)

Prepared by

Binder lives at (room / shelf / drawer)

Backup copy held by (name, phone)

Date started

Last full review

How to use it

1. Start with page 2. The Emergency Quick Sheet is the one page a paramedic, ER nurse, or backup caregiver needs. Print two copies: one on the fridge, one in your bag.

2. Fill in pages 3-5 next (medications, doctors, insurance). These answer most questions at any appointment.

3. Do pages 6-10 over the following weeks (legal documents, bills, expenses, home contacts, account index). Don't try to finish in one sitting.

4. Use page 11 daily as the incident and symptom log from the Chapter 2 triage system, and **page 12 monthly** to keep everything current.

5. Do it with your parent whenever possible. The binder works best (and is respectful) when your parent knows what is in it and who can see it.

Privacy rule. This binder holds sensitive information. Never write passwords, PINs, a full Social Security number, a full Medicare number, or full bank or card numbers on these pages. Use the **last 4 digits only**. Store full numbers and logins in a password manager, and tell the backup person how to reach it. Keep the binder in a private spot, not in a visible place for visitors or service workers.

KEEP ON PAPER (in this binder)

- Emergency Quick Sheet (fridge copy)
- Dated medication list
- Doctor, pharmacy, and helper contacts
- Copies of insurance cards (front and back)
- Copies of health care power of attorney, advance directive, and HIPAA release
- Legal document location sheet (page 6)
- Incident log and monthly checklist

Why: paper works when the power is out, the phone is dead, or the person helping isn't tech-comfortable.

KEEP IN SECURE DIGITAL STORAGE

- Scans or photos of every page of this binder
- Scans of insurance cards, legal documents, and statements
- Logins in a **password manager** with an emergency-access option (several mainstream ones offer a trusted contact who can request access after a waiting period you set)
- Tax records, receipts, and the expense log
- Photos of pill bottle labels

Not in either: originals of the will and powers of attorney. Keep those in a fireproof safe or with the attorney, and tell agents where. *Never send passwords or full SSNs by text or email.*

Filling it in on a computer. The boxes are typeable fields in Adobe Acrobat Reader, Apple Preview, and most browsers: click a box and type. Save a copy under a new name after you type. If your viewer will not keep what you typed, print the pages and write by hand. Either way, keep one paper copy where a backup person can find it.

Emergency Quick Sheet

Fridge copy. Hand this to paramedics or the ER. Update whenever anything changes (date it).

Full name

Date of birth

Phone

Home address (and how to get in: lockbox with whom, NOT the code)

Preferred hospital / health system

Allergies and reactions

Major diagnoses and past surgeries

Devices / implants (pacemaker, stents, joint replacements, oxygen)

Baseline: how they normally walk, talk, and think

ALERTS (check all that apply)

- ☐ Takes blood thinner
- ☐ Diabetes / insulin
- ☐ Dementia / memory loss
- ☐ Hard of hearing
- ☐ Glasses / hearing aids / dentures
- ☐ Fall risk
- ☐ Lives alone
- ☐ Pets at home

Advance directive / living will?

DNR / POLST on file?

Where the documents are

PEOPLE TO CALL (in order)

Role	Name	Relationship	Phone	Notes (best times, has key?)
Health care agent				
Emergency contact #1				
Emergency contact #2				
Out-of-state contact				
Primary doctor				
Pharmacy				

Medicare (Original or Advantage?) / plan name

Member ID (last 4 only)

Plan phone

Medication list is on page 3. Last updated (date) and anything urgent for responders to know:

Medications

Every prescription, over-the-counter product, and supplement. Compare to the bottles each month.

Medication and strength	Dose / how often	What it's for	Prescriber	Pharmacy	Started / changed	Refill due	Stop? Notes

OVER-THE-COUNTER MEDICINES AND SUPPLEMENTS

Product	Dose / how often	Why they take it	Told the doctor? (Y/N)	Notes

Known drug reactions / intolerances

Pharmacist review done (date)

Pharmacy refill sync? (Y/N)

Tip: ask the pharmacy for a printed list, photograph every bottle label, and keep medicines in their original packaging. Use one pharmacy if you can; it helps catch duplicates and interactions.

Doctors, Providers, and Pharmacy

Who to call for what. Add the after-hours number and portal info while you're at it.

Role / specialty	Name	Practice and address	Phone	After-hours / portal	Next appt

Who handles referrals and prior authorizations at the primary doctor's office (name, direct line):

Insurance and Benefits

Copy cards front and back and keep copies here. Last 4 digits of IDs only.

Coverage type	Company / plan name	ID (last 4)	Phone	Referral or prior auth needed?	Where the card is	Notes
Original Medicare (A/B)						
Medicare Advantage						
Medigap / supplement						
Part D drug plan						
Medicaid						
Long-term care ins.						
VA / TRICARE						
Retiree / other						
Dental / vision / hearing						

Medicare Summary Notice (MSN) review. Original Medicare sends one every three months (Medicare Advantage plans send an Explanation of Benefits instead). Check each for services your parent didn't receive. Medicare will never call to ask for a Medicare number. Report suspicious billing to 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227).

☐ MSN reviewed Q1 ☐ MSN reviewed Q2 ☐ MSN reviewed Q3 ☐ MSN reviewed Q4

CLAIMS AND BILLING QUESTIONS TRACKER

Date	Provider / insurer	Problem or question	Who I spoke with	Reference #	Outcome / next step

Legal Documents Location Sheet

Where each original and copy lives, and who is named. Copies here; originals in a fireproof safe or with the attorney.

Document	Exists? (Y / N / in progress)	Date signed	Agent / executor named	Original is at	Copies held by	Attorney / phone
Health care power of attorney						
Financial power of attorney						
Living will / advance directive						
POLST / DNR order						
HIPAA authorization (doctor sharing)						
Will						
Trust						
Deed(s) / property title						
Vehicle title						
Life insurance policies						
Burial / funeral arrangements						
Bank 'trusted contact' form						

Storage notes. Banks and courts usually want the **original** power of attorney. If an agent needs the original to open a safe deposit box, don't store the original there. A bank may also freeze a box after a death until a court order is issued. Tell each named agent where the originals are and how to get them. Laws vary by state; ask an elder law attorney.

Safe / lockbox location (not the combination)

Who knows the combination or holds the key (name)

Documents still needed / next step (and date I'll call the attorney):

Bills and Income

Every recurring bill and where the money comes from. Last 4 digits of account numbers only.

Bill / payee	Acct # (last 4)	Amount	Due (day)	Autopay? (Y/N)	Paid from (account)	Who handles	Notes / phone

INCOME SOURCES

Source (Social Security, pension, annuity, other)	Amount	Deposit day	Deposited to (account, last 4)	Notes

Tip: autopay plus a monthly review beats trying to remember due dates. Even when autopay handles the payment, someone should look at each statement every month for charges that don't belong.

Expenses and Reimbursements Log

If you pay for anything for your parent, write it down the same day. Keep every receipt.

Why this page matters. If you manage money under a power of attorney, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guidance is to keep a detailed list of money spent, keep receipts, avoid paying in cash, and keep your money separate from your parent's (pay your parent's expenses from your parent's funds, and avoid joint accounts). Good records also protect you from family disputes and help at tax time.

Date	Paid to	What for	Amount	Paid with (mine / parent's)	Receipt saved?	Medical? (Y/N)	Reimbursed (date, by whom)

Tax note: if you itemize and your parent was your dependent (either when the care was provided or when you paid), you may be able to deduct the part of their unreimbursed medical costs you paid that exceeds 7.5% of your adjusted gross income. Dependency tests and income limits change yearly; confirm with a tax preparer.

Backup Network, Home, and Service Providers

The people who can show up, and the businesses you'll need on a bad day.

LOCAL BACKUP NETWORK

Role	Name	Phone	Has a key? (Y/N)	Notes (hours, limits)
Eyes (neighbor / check-in)				
Hands (within 1 hour)				
Rides and errands				
Emergency alternate				
Out-of-town family				

HOME AND SERVICE PROVIDERS

Service	Company / person	Phone	Account # (last 4) / access notes
Home care / aide agency			
Plumber			
Electrician			
HVAC			
Locksmith / key holder			
Lawn / snow			
Medical equipment supplier			
Meals / delivery			
Medical alert provider			
Landlord / HOA / building			

Other (add your own)	Company / person	Phone	Notes

Accounts and Digital Access Index

Where things are and who can reach them. NO passwords, PINs, or security answers on this page.

This is a map, not a vault. Write where each login is stored (for example, 'password manager') and who has been given access, never the login itself. Use a password manager with emergency access, and add two-factor sign-in. Don't share passwords by text or email. Where possible, use official proxy or delegate access (for example, patient portal proxy access) instead of sharing your parent's login.

Account	Institution	Online access? (Y/N)	Login is stored in	Who has access	Notes (2-step sign-in device)
Checking					
Savings					
Investments / retirement					
Social Security online					
Medicare.gov account					
Patient portal #1					
Patient portal #2					
Pharmacy account					
Email					
Phone carrier / device					
Utilities					
Credit cards					

Password manager used (name)

Emergency access set up for (name)

Where recovery codes / emergency kit are kept

Who holds the phone's lock code (name, NOT the code)

Doctors' offices where my name is on file as an authorized contact:

Incident and Symptom Log

Facts only: what you saw, when, and what you did. Use it to spot patterns and brief the doctor.

Date / time	What happened (facts, not labels)	Change from normal?	Color (R / Y / G)	Who I contacted	What they said / did	Follow-up due

Red = call 911. Yellow = call a clinician today. Green = goes into the 30-day plan. Sudden changes (confusion, a fall, new weakness, new suspicion) are never 'just aging.'

Monthly Maintenance Checklist

Ten minutes a month keeps the binder useful. Check each box when done.

MONTHLY TASKS	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Update the medication list; compare it to the bottles	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Check refills; confirm the pharmacy sync date	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Read the incident log; send patterns to the doctor	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Review bills and autopay; look for unusual charges	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
File receipts; update the expense log	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Update contacts (doctors, aides, neighbors)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Check smoke and CO alarms; phone and alert batteries	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Test: can a backup person find this binder and page 2?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

QUARTERLY (every 3 months)

- ☐ Review the Medicare Summary Notice for services not received
- ☐ Hold a short family update call; share the log summary
- ☐ Re-test the care level (Chapter 7): still safe, sustainable, acceptable?
- ☐ Rotate the fridge Quick Sheet; re-photograph insurance cards if changed

YEARLY

- ☐ Book the Medicare Annual Wellness Visit; bring page 2, 3, and 11
- ☐ Review Medicare and drug plan options during the fall enrollment period (typically Oct. 15 - Dec. 7)
- ☐ Gather medical receipts and care costs for the tax preparer
- ☐ Ask the attorney whether documents need updating (and after any major life event)

Next full binder review (date)

Person who checks that I did it (accountability partner)